

THE HEAT BEHIND THE HYPE

Rising temperatures and midday kick-offs could make playing conditions the defining subplot of this tournament.

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The opening line of the FIFA World Cup 2026 official theme song goes — ‘Never felt this free before. I’m high, and I’m getting higher.’ While the words try to capture the idea of a growing free spirit, as it turns out, it will not be the only thing on the rise.

The ‘high’ and the ‘higher’ can just as easily be associated with the blistering temperatures expected at

the summer extravaganza, where 16 venues across the U.S., Canada and Mexico are tuning up to host 104 matches.

For the tournament, largely being held in the U.S., the matter of the heat was flagged a year back when it hosted the revamped FIFA Club World Cup. At the time, players, managers, fans and even the global players’ union FIFPRO raised concerns regarding the conditions.

Atletico Madrid’s Marcos Llorente termed the climate “terribly hot,” adding that, “my toes were sore, my

nails were hurting,” while managers like Paris Saint-Germain’s Luis Enrique and Chelsea’s Enzo Maresca, on various instances, expressed that it was tough to survive 90 minutes on the pitch.

Divide and solve

The backlash, to some extent, has forced football’s governing body to be more pragmatic in divvying up the games this time around.

Spread across four time zones, and keeping global audiences in mind, 43 games are set to kick off

Endurance game: Spread across four time zones, and keeping global audiences in mind, 43 games are set to kick off between 12:00 p.m. and on or before 4 p.m. local time, when the sun is at its fiercest. GETTY IMAGES

